

SOMNATH SEN

IN THE NET
Jharkhand cadre IAS officer Chhavi Ranjan arrives at the ED office in Ranchi for interrogation in the alleged land scam on May 4

JHARKHAND

BABU IN THE DOCK

By Amitabh Srivastava

As Ranchi deputy commissioner from July 2020 to July 2022, Chhavi Ranjan was expected to maintain land records scrupulously. But, on May 4, when the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Ranjan, accusing him of being involved in a slew of illegal land deals, they blamed him for dereliction of that very duty. Among the pieces of evidence against the 2011 batch Jharkhand cadre IAS officer presented by the ED is an instance of Ranjan verbally directing a circle officer to complete the mutation of a one-acre property in the name of one Bishnu Agarwal and his wife Anushree in spite of a dispute relating to it pending before the circle office. A forensic scrutiny of Agarwal's cellphone revealed that he had paid bills for Ranjan's tours in Goa. The arrangements were made through a travel agent in Delhi, who was paid in cash by one of Agarwal's staff.

In a 13-page document submitted to the special CBI and Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court, the agency has blamed Ranjan for allegedly facilitating illegal purchase and sale of several pieces of land, including one owned by the Indian army in Ranchi. On May 16, the court allowed the judicial remand of the 42-year-old till May 25. Ranjan was also suspended from his position of director of Jharkhand's social welfare department.

THE ED HAS ACCUSED RANJAN OF FACILITATING ILLEGAL PURCHASE AND SALE OF LAND

The ED zeroed in on Ranjan while pursuing a case it registered in June 2022 on the basis of an FIR filed with the Ranchi police in 2020. In it, Dilip Sharma, a Ranchi Municipal Corporation tax collector, had accused one Pradip Bagchi of using forged papers to fraudulently acquire the holding number of a property. The ED found it was a 455 decimal (around 4.5 acres) plot in Ranchi that one Laxman Rao had handed over to the army after independence, and which was fraudulently allotted to Bagchi in government records.